



GOVERNANCE DOCUMENT

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International Society of Equity Analysts

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This document forms part of the official governance framework of the International Society of Equity Analysts (ISEA) and should be read together with the related documents listed above.

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1. Purpose

The International Society of Equity Analysts (ISEA) is committed to maintaining high standards of integrity, professionalism, independence, competence and ethical conduct within the global equity research and analysis profession.

This Ethics Policy establishes the ethical framework governing ISEA's Members, holders of ISEA professional certifications and designations, Governing Council members, officers, committee members, volunteers and representatives acting on behalf of ISEA.

ISEA recognises that confidence in equity research and investment analysis depends upon the professionalism, objectivity, competence and ethical conduct of those engaged in the profession.

Accordingly, ISEA has established a **Code of Ethics and Standards of Professional Conduct** ("Code") as the principal ethical and professional framework applicable to ISEA Members and other persons to whom the Code applies.

The Code reflects ISEA's commitment to promoting high standards of professional conduct, strengthening confidence in equity research and supporting the integrity, credibility and development of the global equity analysis profession.

This Ethics Policy operates alongside the Code and other applicable ISEA policies, regulations and governance requirements.

2. Scope and Application

This Ethics Policy applies to:

- the Governing Council members;
- officers of ISEA;
- committee members;
- ISEA Members (Student Members, Associate Members, Members and Fellows);
- holders of ISEA professional certifications and designations;
- volunteers and representatives acting on behalf of ISEA; and
- individuals participating in ISEA-recognised professional activities, where applicable.

The Code applies to the persons and activities specified within that Code.

By becoming a Member of ISEA, obtaining an ISEA certification or designation, holding an ISEA governance or representative position, or participating in an ISEA professional program or activity, an individual acknowledges the ethical obligations applicable to their role.

3. Code of Ethics and Standards of Professional Conduct

ISEA has established the Code as the principal ethical framework governing the professional conduct of its Members and other persons to whom the Code applies.

The Code establishes principles and standards relating to matters including:

- professional integrity and responsibility;
- research independence and objectivity;
- conflicts of interest;
- fair dealing and professional relationships;
- confidentiality and material non-public information;
- research quality and disclosure;
- plagiarism and intellectual integrity;
- technology, automation and artificial intelligence;
- professional competence and continuing development;

- responsibilities to ISEA and the profession; and
- professional misconduct and cooperation with ISEA processes.

Members and other persons subject to the Code are responsible for understanding and complying with the requirements applicable to them.

The Code may be amended from time to time in accordance with ISEA's governance and approval procedures.

4. Relationship Between this Policy and Other ISEA Requirements

This Ethics Policy establishes ISEA's overarching commitment to ethical and professional conduct.

The Code establishes the specific ethical principles and professional standards applicable to Members and other persons within its scope.

This Policy should be read together with other ISEA policies and procedures relevant to ethical conduct, including:

- the **Conflict of Interest Policy**, which establishes requirements for identifying, disclosing and managing conflicts of interest;
- the **Complaints Policy**, which establishes the process for submitting and handling complaints concerning ISEA or persons subject to its requirements;
- the **Disciplinary Policy**, which establishes procedures for the investigation, determination and resolution of alleged breaches of ISEA requirements; and
- the **Whistleblower Policy**, which establishes protected channels for reporting suspected wrongdoing and safeguards against retaliation.

These policies operate together and should be interpreted consistently. Where a matter is subject to a specific procedure established by one of these policies, that procedure shall apply in addition to the substantive ethical requirements established by the Code.

5. Fundamental Ethical Principles

ISEA expects persons within its professional community to uphold the following fundamental principles.

5.1 Integrity

Members shall uphold high standards of professional integrity and act honestly and responsibly in their professional activities.

Members shall avoid conduct that is inconsistent with the ethical standards of ISEA or that could materially undermine confidence in the equity research profession.

5.2 Independence and Objectivity

Members shall maintain independence of judgement and take reasonable steps to identify and manage circumstances that could compromise the objectivity of their research, analysis or recommendations.

Investment conclusions should be based upon appropriate evidence, analysis and professional judgement rather than improper commercial, personal or external influence.

5.3 Professional Competence

Members shall maintain and continually develop the knowledge, skills and analytical capabilities necessary to perform their professional responsibilities competently and effectively.

Members should remain reasonably informed of material developments affecting equity research, financial markets, analytical methodologies, technology and applicable professional requirements.

5.4 Transparency and Disclosure

Members shall provide clear, fair and appropriately prominent disclosure of material matters relevant to their research, analysis and recommendations, including applicable conflicts of interest, material

relationships, significant assumptions, limitations and other matters that could reasonably affect an investment conclusion.

5.5 Responsible Use of Technology and Artificial Intelligence

Members who use artificial intelligence, automated systems, data analytics, programming tools or other technologies in professional activities remain personally responsible for the professional judgement, integrity and accuracy reflected in their work.

Members shall exercise appropriate oversight and verification and shall use technology consistently with their ethical, professional, confidentiality and other applicable obligations.

6. Responsibilities of ISEA Members

Members shall:

- understand and comply with the Code;
- comply with other applicable ISEA policies, regulations and professional requirements;
- maintain appropriate professional competence;
- conduct themselves consistently with the ethical and professional standards of ISEA;
- protect confidential information obtained through their professional activities;
- cooperate reasonably with legitimate ISEA inquiries, investigations and disciplinary processes;
- report credible evidence of professional misconduct through an appropriate channel where required by the Code; and
- avoid conduct that materially undermines the integrity or reputation of ISEA or its professional designations.

The specific obligations of Members are set out in the Code and other applicable ISEA requirements.

7. Responsibilities of Governing Council Members, Officers and Committee Members

Persons holding leadership, governance or committee positions within ISEA have additional responsibilities arising from their roles.

They shall:

- act in the best interests of ISEA;
- exercise independent judgement;
- identify and appropriately manage conflicts of interest;
- maintain the confidentiality of information obtained through their ISEA responsibilities;
- protect the integrity and reputation of ISEA;
- comply with applicable governance and fiduciary obligations;
- exercise appropriate care in the performance of their responsibilities; and
- lead by example in maintaining high standards of ethical and professional conduct.

The Governing Council, officers and committee members shall comply with applicable ISEA governance policies, conflict-of-interest requirements and other obligations applicable to their roles.

8. Conflicts of Interest

ISEA recognises that conflicts of interest may arise in professional, governance, assessment and other activities.

Persons subject to ISEA's conflict-of-interest requirements shall:

- identify actual, potential and relevant perceived conflicts;
- disclose material conflicts appropriately;

- take reasonable steps to manage, mitigate or eliminate conflicts where appropriate; and
- avoid allowing personal, financial, commercial or other interests to improperly influence professional or organisational judgement.

ISEA may establish additional conflict-of-interest procedures applicable to:

- Governing Council members;
- officers;
- committee members;
- certification assessors;
- examination personnel;
- education providers;
- research contributors; and
- other persons performing functions on behalf of ISEA.

9. Professional Misconduct

Professional misconduct is addressed principally through Standard 18 — Professional Misconduct of the Code.

Conduct that may constitute professional misconduct includes, but is not limited to:

- dishonesty;
- fraud or deception;
- plagiarism or intellectual dishonesty;
- falsification or fabrication of research or information;
- material manipulation or distortion of analysis;
- misuse of confidential or material non-public information;
- serious or undisclosed conflicts of interest;
- corruption, bribery or improper inducements;
- market manipulation or other unlawful market conduct;
- misuse or misrepresentation of ISEA membership or professional designations;
- obstruction or improper interference with legitimate ISEA processes; and
- other conduct fundamentally inconsistent with the ethical and professional standards expected of an ISEA professional.

The specific scope of professional misconduct and applicable Member obligations are governed by the ISEA Code.

10. Ethics & Professional Standards Committee

The Ethics & Professional Standards Committee is responsible for overseeing the development, interpretation and implementation of ISEA's ethical and professional standards, subject to the authority of the Governing Council.

The Committee may:

- promote awareness of ISEA's ethical and professional requirements;
- develop ethical guidance and educational materials;
- recommend amendments to the Code and related policies;
- provide guidance on ethical matters;
- review or oversee alleged breaches in accordance with applicable procedures;
- recommend appropriate disciplinary outcomes;

- monitor emerging ethical issues affecting the equity research profession; and
- promote continuous improvement of ISEA's ethical framework.

The Committee shall maintain appropriate confidentiality and procedural fairness in the performance of its responsibilities.

11. Enforcement and Disciplinary Actions

Where an individual is alleged to have breached the Code, this Ethics Policy or another applicable ISEA requirement, ISEA may undertake an appropriate review, investigation or disciplinary process.

ISEA's disciplinary procedures shall be designed to provide:

- procedural fairness;
- an appropriate opportunity for the individual to respond;
- consideration of relevant evidence;
- impartial consideration of the matter where practicable; and
- proportionate outcomes having regard to the nature and circumstances of the conduct.

Subject to applicable ISEA disciplinary procedures, possible outcomes may include:

- education or remediation;
- formal warning;
- reprimand;
- suspension of membership;
- suspension or withdrawal of an ISEA certification or designation;
- restrictions on participation in ISEA activities;
- termination of membership; or
- referral to a relevant regulatory, professional or other appropriate body.

12. Confidentiality and Privacy

ISEA shall handle information concerning ethical matters, complaints, investigations and disciplinary proceedings with appropriate confidentiality and in accordance with applicable privacy and other legal requirements.

Information may be disclosed where:

- required by law;
- authorised under applicable ISEA procedures;
- necessary for the proper conduct of an investigation or disciplinary process;
- necessary to protect the integrity of ISEA or its professional standards;
- required for legitimate regulatory or professional cooperation; or
- otherwise authorised by the Governing Council or an authorised ISEA body.

ISEA shall seek to balance appropriate confidentiality with the requirements of procedural fairness, regulatory cooperation and the proper administration of its professional standards.

13. Review and Continuous Improvement

ISEA shall periodically review this Ethics Policy and its broader ethical framework to ensure that they remain appropriate having regard to:

- developments in equity research and investment analysis;
- international professional practices;
- regulatory and legal developments;

- technological and artificial intelligence developments;
- emerging ethical issues; and
- the evolving needs of the equity research profession.

The Ethics & Professional Standards Committee shall recommend amendments where appropriate, subject to approval by the Governing Council.

ISEA may also amend its Code through the governance process established for that Code.

14. Effective Date

This Ethics Policy takes effect on the date approved by the Governing Council.